As pressure from the Indian government and the local population grew, the French attempted to delay re-integration. However, they showed remarkable restraint compared to how they reacted in Algeria and Vietnam. Perhaps they recognized the inevitable. In June 1949, Chandannagar opted to merge with India, and a year later it was integrated with the state of West Bengal. The French hung on to their enclaves in southern India for a few more years, but the situation was growing increasingly tense on the ground. Finally, in 1954, the French handed over the rest of the territories.[7]

Pondicherry, renamed Puducherry, is today a Union Territory (i.e. a province directly ruled by the central government) but most Indians do not realize that it also includes the three other enclaves of Yanam, Mahé and Karaikal. French influence lives on in many ways. The main town of Puducherry retains many colonial-era buildings as well as the rigid street-grid designed by the French. Many locals even hold French citizenship, descendants of those who chose to remain French at the time of the handover. Perhaps the most thriving of French legacies, however, is also the most unexpected: a community set up by a Bengali revolutionary, Aurobindo Ghosh, who fled British India in 1910 to avoid arrest and was granted asylum by the authorities in Pondicherry. Here he shifted his focus from politics to spirituality and attracted a huge following. Although the movement has branches all over India and abroad, Pondicherry remains home to many institutions as well as a commune inspired by the spiritual leader.

Having tackled the French, New Delhi now turned its attention to the Portuguese. The Portuguese held several small enclaves along the western coast. Goa was the single largest territory, but there were also Diu, Daman, Dadra, and Nagar-Haveli. In the sixteenth century, the Portuguese had used a network of such enclaves to enforce their control over the Indian Ocean. Although much diminished in power by the twentieth century, they had survived Vijayanagar, the Mughals and the British. They saw no reason why they should leave just because India had been declared a Republic. The Portuguese dictator Antonio Salazar condescendingly declared that Goa represented the ‘light of the West in the Orient’.